PSCI 3328 - International Relations

Lecture 2 - Where Did the Current International System Come From?

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PSCI 3328 - Attendance

Introduction

- Please complete the form for Team final project
  - Send an email asap if you want to be on a team with somebody
- Reminder: you can contribute to participation by posting a question + responding on eLearning's Forum feature
- Today: on where the International System came from and intro to core concepts

Today's Schedule

1. Core Concepts of International Relations
2. The "Westphalian Story"
3. Alternative International Systems
4. So What? Taking Stake of the International Systems Debate

Part I: Core Concepts

What is an international system?

Key Concept: System

From Ringmar: A **system** is "*something made up of units that act independently of each other*"

- Units (states) that "*act independently of each other at the same time as they are forced to consider the actions of all other entities in the system*"
- Systems are made up of **institutions, rules, and norms**
- The system "provides an environment which determines, in broad outline, what political entities do and what they cannot do"

Anything problematic with these definitions or their consideration as foundational concepts?

Key Concept: Sovereignty

Sovereignty: "(A sovereign state is a state that exercises supreme authority within a given territory)" (addendum: as recognized by other actors)

What does this mean in practice?

- The whole world is divided up based on **borders**
- Sharp lines that indicate ostensible political control of a government
- No higher authority above the state within its territory

Key Concept: Anarchy

Not chaos! In IR, **anarchy** means:

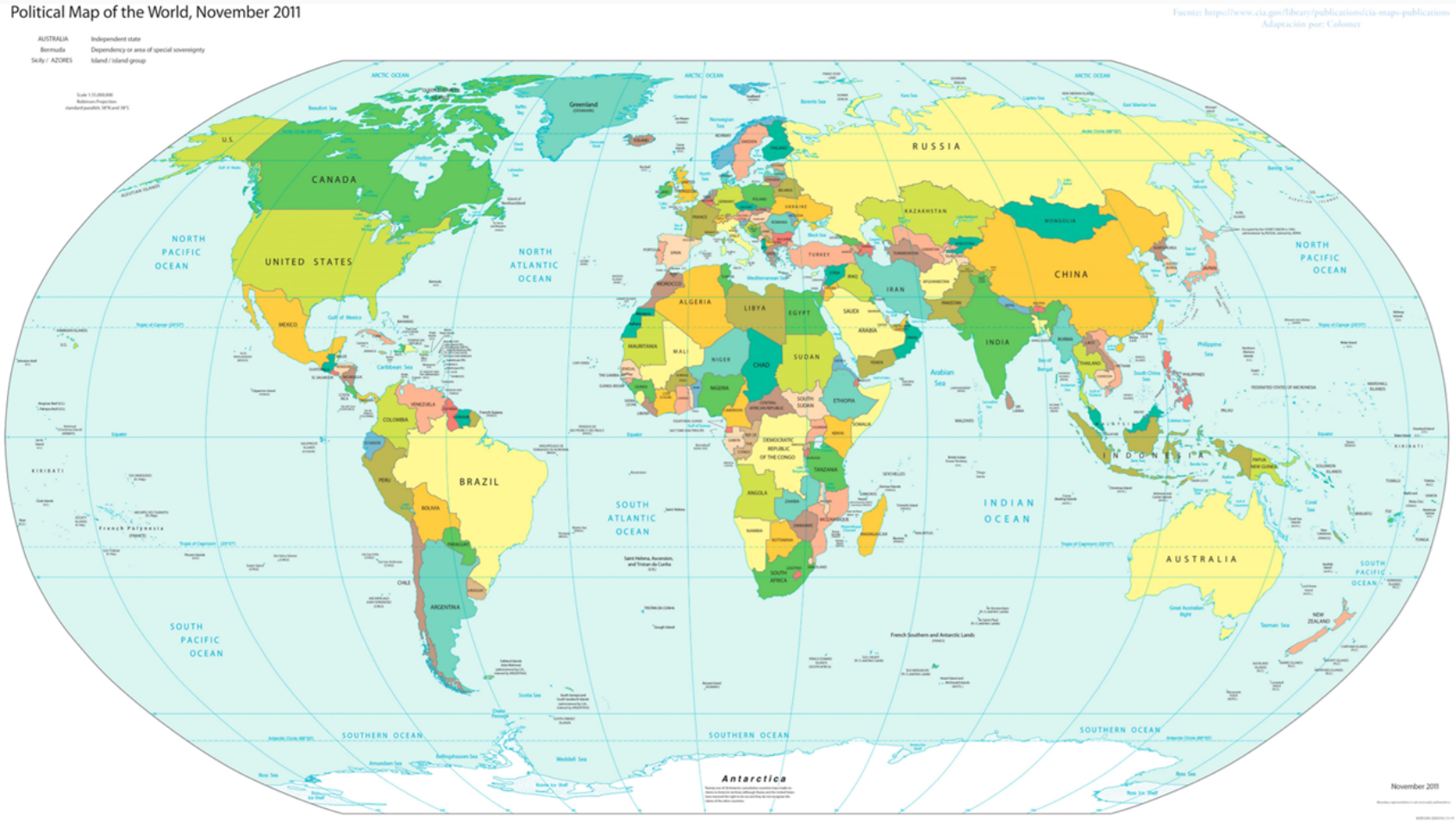
- No overarching world government
- States interact as independent units
- No supreme authority to enforce rules

Key structuring principle: Sovereign states interacting in anarchy

Key Concept: Anarchy

Is this class in a state of anarchy?

The Contemporary Political Map



Discussion Question: What is shown on this map? What is *not* shown?

What the Map Shows (and Hides)

Shown:

- Fixed territorial borders
- Sovereign states as primary actors
- A world completely divided into political units

Hidden:

- Other forms of political organization
- Nomadic peoples
- Sub-state and trans-state identities
- Networks of trade, religion, culture

The “Westphalian Story”

(Simplified) Before 1648: Chaos and Conflict

- Europe divided between competing authorities
  - Holy Roman Emperor
  - Pope
  - Kings and princes
- Conflicting claims to political control (especially over religion)
- Led to devastating conflict: **The Thirty Years' War** (1618-1648)

The Peace of Westphalia (1648)

Europeans “invented” the sovereign state to solve the problem:

1. The king/ruler has **ultimate authority** over his realm
2. Realms are defined by **borders**
3. International politics = interactions between these sovereign units

Key principle: *Cuius regio, eius religio* (whose realm, his religion)

The Westphalian map: Relatively similar to what we have today

Europe (AD 1648) ~
The Peace of Westphalia
House of Habsburg :
Spanish line
Austrian line
House of Hohenzollern :
Brandenburgian line
Franconian - Swabian line
Frontier of the H.R.E
Free Imperial Cities
Ottoman Empire & its vassals
Abbreviations :
K. = Kingdom , Rep. = Republic , P. = Principality , D. = Duchy , Archd. = Archduchy , Gr. D. = Grand Duchy , E. = Electorate , M. = Margraviate
K. OF NORWAY
K. OF SWEDEN
K. OF SCOTLAND
K. OF ENGLAND
K. OF DENMARK
UNITED PROVINCES
HOLY ROMAN EMPIRE
K. OF FRANCE
K. OF SPAIN
K. OF PORTUGAL
POLAND-LITHUANIA
TSARDOM OF RUSSIA
OTTOMAN EMPIRE
REP. OF VENICE
PAPAL STATE
K. of Naples
K. of Sicily
K. of Sardinia
Corsica
Estonia
Livonia
Courland
Lithuania
White Russia
Ukraine
Podolia
Crimean Khanate
Moldavia
Transylvania
Wallachia
Hungary
Austria
Bohemia
Moravia
Bavaria
Hessen
Brandenburg
Saxony
Mecklenburg
Holstein
Great Poland
Mazovia
Podlachia
Prussia
Silesia
Normandy
Picardy
Brittany
Maine
Bourgogne
Gascogne
Auvergne
Dauphine
Provence
Savoy
Milan
Swiss Confederation
Tyrol
Castile
Aragon
Catalonia
Navarre
Andalusia
Galicia
Algarve
Bosnia
Serbia
Bulgaria
Rumelia
Anatolia
Cyprus
Crete
Algeria
Tunis
MOROCCO
Sicily
Malta
Sardinia
Corsica
Balearic Is.
Ireland
Wales
Scotland
Norway
Sweden
Finland
Denmark
North Sea
Baltic Sea
ATLANTIC OCEAN
Black Sea
MEDITERRANEAN SEA
Adriatic Sea
Tyrrhenian Sea
Ionian Sea
Aegean Sea
English Channel
Circassians
Abkhazia
Cyprus
Palestine
Syria
Karaman
Rhodes
Candia
Malta
Djerba
Algarve
Balearic Is.
Minorca
Majorca
Ibiza
Sicily
Sardinia
Corsica
Orkney Is.
Shetland Is.
Hebrides
Aland Is.
Dago
Osel
Gotland
Oland
Bornholm
Rügen
Helgoland
Texel
Zeeland
Jersey
Guernsey
Isle of Man
Ulster
Leinster
Munster
Connaught
Northumberland
Cumberland
Westmorland
Norfolk
Devon
Sussex
Wessex
Essex
Kent
Sussex
Brittany
Normandy
Picardy
Maine
Bourgogne
Gascogne
Auvergne
Dauphine
Provence
Savoy
Milan
Genoa
Parma
Modena
Tuscany
Papal State
Naples
Sicily
Sardinia
Corsica
Balearic Is.
Minorca
Majorca
Ibiza
Malta
Djerba
Tunis
Algeria
MOROCCO
Algarve
Galicia
Castile
Aragon
Catalonia
Navarre
Andalusia
Valencia
Murcia
Extremadura
Leon
Old Castile
Asturias
Basque Country
Aquitaine
Limoges
Orleans
Paris
Champagne
Lorraine
Burgundy
Provence
Dauphine

European Expansion

- Europeans spread this system to the rest of the world
- Created empires through technological superiority
  - Railroads
  - Steamships
  - Military technology
- By the 20th century, European empires had more or less taken over the world

Decolonization

- After WWII, the empires left
- Gave independence to their former colonies
- A few “dust-ups” later → we end up with ~196 countries today
- Former colonies adopted the Westphalian state system

How is This Relevant?

So, what is the context behind the start of standard IR theory? Why is this taken as the starting point of sovereign states?

What Gets Left Out?

Discussion Question

What is left out of the Westphalian story?

Three Major Omissions

1. **Ignores most of human history**
   - Treats 1648 as the beginning of international politics
2. **Reduces most of the world to passive actors**
   - Non-Europeans only appear in reaction to Europeans
   - Reproduces racial hierarchies
3. **Treats one system as inevitable**
   - Can't compare international systems
   - Limits our ability to understand current system in context

What are your thoughts?

Nomadic Peoples

Most of human history: Hunter-gatherer bands and pastoralists

- A system of fixed geography, fixed property rights, land ownership is **relatively recent**
- Nomadic peoples have been major political forces
  - Mongol Empire under Genghis Khan nearly conquered all of Eurasia
  - Only in 19th century did states effectively "subdue the barbarians" (railroads!)

Nomadic Peoples Today

Even today, mismatches persist:

- Fulani in West Africa live semi-nomadic lives with cattle herds
- Put them in conflict with farmers and fixed borders
- Territorial sovereignty doesn't fit how large populations actually live

Key point: Fixed territorial sovereignty is not the only way to organize political life

Omission: Systems in other Regions (Africa, China...)

From Ringmar Chapter 6:

Different geography → different systems

- Abundance of land made territorial expansion less important
- Empires grew through **trade** and control over natural resources
- Example: Mansa Musa, Emperor of Mali (1300s)
  - Possibly the richest person who ever lived
  - Half the world's gold came from Africa
  - His spending literally ruined economies

African International Relations

- Complex interactions based on:
  - Trade relationships
  - Religious spread (Islam)
  - Bantu migrations from West Africa
- Lengthy history of Egypt and Nubia in North Africa, Mali, and many others

Massive international trade happening before European empires arrived

The Chinese International System

More **hierarchical structure**:

- Other political organizations existed in relationship with the empire
- Shared loyalty to central authority even among relatively independent units
- **Tribute system**: acknowledgment of Chinese centrality
- Different from European model of equal sovereignty

So What? Why Does This Matter?

So What? Why Does This Matter?

Your thoughts?

The Debate: Classic IR vs. Alternative Systems

- Structural foundation of Westphalia for IR theory
  - Implications for how we understand power, cooperation, conflict
- Alternative systems:
  - Allows us to question assumptions about sovereignty, anarchy, statehood

Summarizing the: “So what”

1. **Historical contingency** vs. inevitability (we could have had a different system)
2. **Alternative futures** are possible
3. **Understanding contemporary problems**

Some questions you brought up

1. Are we forcing non-European political systems into a European conceptual framework that may not fully apply?
2. Why was something so positive like this expansion [In terms of communication, trade, growth] tied to such a contradictory result like cultural destruction?
3. Why is this part of history [Other ones, like Africa] less visible in the mainstream narratives today?
4. Would it even be possible to change our current system?

Summary

1. Key concepts in IR are still foundational
2. The Westphalian story is relatively simplistic and not as key as it is given credit to it (still relevant in its own way)
3. Much to be considered when thinking about international systems
4. Alternative systems help us question assumptions and think critically about the current international order

Looking Ahead

Next class: Anarchy and Hierarchy

Key questions to think about:

- If the international system is "anarchic," what does that really mean?
- Is anarchy the only way to describe international politics?
- What's the difference between anarchy and hierarchy?

Do the readings!

Questions?